

Making Music with LINUX

Here's how to convert your Linux box into a jukebox



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Linux is often associated with the command line and servers, but lately it's been growing in popularity as a desktop solution. Most people, however, are still scared of the very word Linux. Ask them "Why?", and they cite various reasons ranging from, "Linux doesn't have proper applications," to "No way man, I need to play games, watch my movies and blast my MP3s"... but wait! Who said you can't listen to music on Linux? Read on to see how you can edit and listen to

music, and make your Linux box sing to you... literally.

Learn to walk before you run

Before you do anything with any operating system, you need to make sure the correct drivers are installed and working—Linux is no exception. With Linux, there are so many drivers that it can be confusing at times.

Advanced Linux Sound Architecture (ALSA): ALSA was developed by a group of

Linux developers who were frustrated by the lack of sound card support on Linux. In an attempt to provide better support, they completely abandoned all existing Linux sound card drivers and started writing their own drivers from scratch. Using ALSA doesn't restrict you to only ALSA-aware applications—there are OSS emulation modules that provide good support for strictly OSS-compatible applications as well.

In order to install ALSA, you will have to download five different packages:

```
alsa-driver-0.9.8.tar.bz2
alsa-oss-0.9.8.tar.bz2
alsa-utils-0.9.8.tar.bz2
alsa-lib-0.9.8.tar.bz2
alsa-tools-0.9.8.tar.bz2
```

After uncompressing each of them using the **'bunzip2'** command, **'cd'** into each respective directory in the order above and use the following commands to install them.:

```
./configure
make
make install
```

After this, go to **'/dev/'** and type the following command:

```
./snddevices'
```

This will create the **'/dev/snd'** directory, and set up all the necessary devices required for using ALSA in other applications.

Playing the field

There is certainly no shortage of MP3 players for Linux. In fact, most of these players will play almost every music format available today—except for a few Microsoft file formats, due to licensing problems.

XMMS

XMMS is by far the most popular MP3 player on Linux. It is a Winamp clone with most of its features including playlists, presets, etc.—it can even import Winamp presets and equalizer settings. It provides a variety of output and visualization plug-ins that can make listening to music a pleasure.

XMMS comes pre-installed with almost every Linux distribution, but if it isn't installed on your system, just download either the source files of the latest version from www.xmms.org. The latest version is `xmms-1.2.8.tar.gz` or `xmms-1.2.8.tar.bz2`, or you can download the binary packages (.rpm files) for your distribution. XMMS needs some very basic system libraries, but don't worry, these are generally installed with every Linux distribution. To install XMMS from the source code, uncompress the file using the **'tar xzf'** or **'tar jxvf'** commands.